Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Titus

Titus 1:1

knowledge ... that leads to godliness: See 2:11–14; 1 Timothy 6:3.

Titus 1:1–4

The beginning of the book of Titus, like that of 1 Timothy (1:1–2), establishes Paul's authority for his representative.

Titus 1:2

- Believing that they have eternal life enables God's people to live well now (see 2:11–14; 3:7–8).
- God, who cannot lie: The true God contrasts with popular Cretan ideas (see study note on 1:12). This statement also emphasizes God's plan of salvation as unchanging (1:1): God can be trusted to fulfill his promises (see Numbers 23:19; 1 Samuel 15:29; Romans 3:3–4).

Titus 1:3

- In His own time: The initiative is entirely with God, who fulfills his plan on his own schedule by his own will (see 3:5; 1 Timothy 2:6; 2 Timothy 1:10).
- God our Savior: In Titus 1:4, Jesus is also called "our Savior," identifying Jesus with God (see 2:10, 13; 3:4, 6).

Titus 1:4

- Titus was Paul's delegate in dealing with the church in Crete. A delegate is someone who is sent to represent another person.
- my true child: The wording authorizes the delegate (as in 1 Timothy 1:2).

Titus 1:5

- Crete was located in the Mediterranean, south of the Aegean Sea. It was an important location for travel and trade by sea, so it had a mix of influences, including a Jewish population. Some from Crete had been at Pentecost (Acts 2:11), but this letter seems to deal with a church in the early stages of development.
- elders in every town: There may have been more than one house church in a given town and possibly more than one elder in a given house church. Clearly, there were churches in at least two towns and the leadership was specific to each town.

Titus 1:5–9

- Titus was instructed to appoint leaders in order to complete what was unfinished—that is, to establish the church (compare 1 Timothy 3:1–13). Deacons are not mentioned, possibly because these were new, small churches.
- These leadership qualities might be an accommodation to the newness of these converts and the roughness of their culture. It is assumed that the elders will be male (see 1 Timothy 3:4–5).

Titus 1:5–16

Strong, faithful leadership was needed in the churches of Crete to address the danger of false teachers (1:10–16). This part of Titus's task coincides with the larger concern of the letter: to shape a community that bears witness to Christ by embodying God's grace in its conduct. Compare 1 Timothy 3:1–7.

Titus 1:6

- the husband of one wife (or faithful to his wife): See study note on 1 Timothy 3:2.
- indiscretion or insubordination (that is, reckless behavior or rebellion): This probably reflects Cretan culture with its low moral standards (Titus 1:12).

Titus 1:7

- A church leader (or An overseer, or A bishop) is a manager of God's household: See 1:11; 2:2–10; 1 Timothy 1:4; 3:4–5, 12, 15; 2 Timothy 2:20–21.
- These qualities indicate that an elder should not behave like the people in Crete known for their immorality (see Titus 1:12).

Titus 1:9

- The elders had a leading role in teaching the community. This may have been necessary in dealing with the immediate threat to these particular communities (as also in Ephesus; see 1 Timothy 3:1).
- Only with a strong belief in the good news would an elder be able to provide sound teaching. Paul's specific concerns are addressed in Titus 2:1–3:11, considering the problems mentioned in 1:10–16 and 3:9–11 (see also 1 Timothy 1:10).
- Titus had a similar role (compare Titus 1:13; 2:15; 3:10–11). The local leadership would continue the work Paul and his delegates started.
- Those who oppose it are described in 1:10–16.

Titus 1:10

- rebellious: The same Greek word is used of children in 1:6.

- those who insist on circumcision for salvation (literally those of the circumcision): This probably refers to Jewish Christians. The Greek phrase does not specify whether or not they required Gentiles to be circumcised. The Jewish influence of this false teaching is suggested in 1:14–15 and 3:9.

Titus 1:10–16

In a native population of troublemakers, Titus would need to lead firmly to rid these Christian communities of corruption and make them healthy in the faith (1:13–16).

Titus 1:11

- entire households: This also happened in Ephesus (compare 1 Timothy 4:3; 2 Timothy 2:18; 3:6).
- for the sake of dishonorable gain: Elders must not have this characteristic (Titus 1:7; see also 1 Timothy 6:5–10; 2 Corinthians 2:17; 1 Peter 5:2).

Titus 1:12

- one of their own prophets: This quotation is from Epimenides of Knossos, a philosopher who lived on Crete around the 500s BC.
- liars: This charge was directed specifically at the Cretan claim to have Zeus's tomb on the island. According to Cretan mythology, the god Zeus was once a mere human who lived and died on Crete. His tomb was said to be there. But Zeus had achieved godhood through his patronage (that is, gifts and benefits) to humans. Some Greek moralists opposed this legend and characterized it as a lie. A quote from Alexandria in the 200s BC reads: "Cretans are always liars. For a tomb, O Lord, Cretans build for you; but you do not die, for you are forever." One of Crete's own prophets (Epimenides) thought the same thing. Paul cites his voice of conscience approvingly (Titus 1:13; see Acts 17:28), for the God who does not lie (Titus 1:2) opposes the lies of such myths.
- liars ... beasts ... gluttons: It was believed that Cretan immorality resulted from their belief about Zeus. Religious lies had led to moral corruption. Paul later counters these vices by presenting the contrasting virtues (positive qualities or behaviors) (Titus 2:12). He urges the Cretans to reach ethical ideals that are praised in human society generally but were absent on Crete, as bemoaned by their own prophet. They would reach these ideals only through the gospel of Jesus Christ (2:11–14).
- lazy gluttons: Cretans were known to do anything for money. They were well-known as mercenaries and as excessive consumers. They were said to feel no shame in their greed (see Philippians 3:19).
- Paul applies the quotation more directly to the current false teachers than to Cretan culture generally. The false teachers carried on this Cretan tradition of immorality based on a lie.

Titus 1:13

- This testimony is true: See study note on 1:12.
- Being sound (or strong) in the faith is here defined as rejecting false teachings (compare 1:9).

Titus 1:14

- Jewish myths: See 3:9; 1 Timothy 1:4; 4:7; 2 Timothy 4:4.
- have rejected the truth: This was apostasy not mere unbelief. Apostasy is when someone abandons or rejects their beliefs. See 1 Timothy 1:6–7.

Titus 1:15

Compare 1 Timothy 4:3–5.

Titus 1:15–16

These two verses comment on the people of 1:14 and their commands, while transitioning to a discussion on teaching that encourages goodness (2:1–3:11).

Titus 1:16

- Sound teaching and godliness are always linked together in the letters to Timothy and Titus (see 1 Timothy 1:7–11; 3:15–16; 5:24–25; 2 Timothy 3:5, 9). Similarly, the ungodly way they live is connected with false teaching.
- any good deed: This contrasts with Titus 3:1.

Titus 2:1–15

Sound teaching was especially urgent on account of the false teachers, who had caused problems within "entire households" (1:11). In 2:1–10, Paul addresses different groups within the household of faith, showing his concern for the public testimony of the church (2:5, 8, 10; see also 1 Tim 5:1–6:2). Paul then elaborates on the coming of Christ (Titus 2:11–14) before giving a direct charge to Titus (2:15).

Titus 2:9–10

The purpose of these commands is to "adorn the teaching about God" The New Living Translation translates it this way: "make the teaching about God ... attractive" (see 1 Timothy 6:1–2).

Titus 2:11

- has been revealed (literally has appeared): See study note on 1 Timothy 6:14.
- salvation to everyone: Paul intends that God's grace will fully accomplish its purposes among the Cretans and that, in doing so, it will enlist them into God's saving work of evangelism (Titus 2:12; see 1 Timothy 2:1–7; 4:10).

Titus 2:11–15

For: The commands of 2:1–10 are here grounded in the past and future coming of Christ. God's grace is a model for the church's own conduct, even as salvation by grace makes a good life possible and creates people devoted to good works (see also 3:3–7).

Titus 2:12

- It instructs us: The emphasis of this instruction falls on the positive virtues: wisdom, righteousness, and devotion to God. In Greco-Roman writings, these three virtues represent virtuous behavior in general. These virtues counter the Cretan vices (immoral behaviors or qualities) listed in 1:12 and are transformed into thoroughly Christian qualities (see 2:13).
- Paul encourages the Cretans to embody these virtues, in order to clearly show their fellow Cretans that a virtuous life comes only from God's grace in Jesus Christ.

Titus 2:13

- we await: This implies hope as well as future accountability, both of which encourage godly behavior in the present.
- appearance: The Greek word used here is prominent in the letters to Timothy and Titus ("epiphany" or "appearing"; also 2:11; see study note on 1 Timothy 6:14).
- great God and Savior: This is one of the few places in the New Testament where Jesus Christ is explicitly called "God" (see also John 1:1; 20:28; Romans 9:5; Hebrews 1:8; 2 Peter 1:1; possibly John 1:18). Yet this claim is entirely consistent with the roles and attributes of Christ and the worship that he receives. It is possible this title is used here to assert that Christ is not a mere human elevated to the status of other gods (see study note on Titus 1:12). When this letter was written, Christians were insisting more and more that Christ alone, rather than rulers and emperors, should be called divine.

Titus 2:14

- Salvation produces a people who have the desire for and ability to do the good deeds described in 2:2–10.
- He gave Himself: See also 1 Timothy 2:6.
- to redeem us: See Galatians 3:22; 4:4–5; compare Exodus 6:6–8.
- The phrase "a people for His own possession" recalls the formation of Israel as a nation (see Exodus 19:5; Deuteronomy 7:6; 14:2). Those who follow Christ are now God's people—his nation—and the Spirit leads them to keep God's covenant.
- totally committed to doing good deeds (literally zealous for good deeds): See Titus 1:16; Ephesians 2:10.

Titus 3:1

- Paul might be telling the believers to make a clear distinction between themselves and the disorderly general population. Alternatively, the troublemakers (1:10–15; 3:10) might have adopted disorderly behaviors as a result of their false teachings (as is likely the case in 1 Timothy 2:1–7).
- On relations to rulers and authorities, see 1 Timothy 2:2; Romans 13:1–7.

Titus 3:1–11

The emphasis on sound teaching continues (1:9; 2:1). Now Paul shifts his focus to how the Christian community relates to society in general (compare 1 Timothy 2:2–4). As in Titus 2:1–15, God's instructions for his people in 3:1–2 are based on his interactions with them (3:3–7; compare study note on 2:11–15). Paul then instructs Titus to avoid pointless arguments and to insist on beneficial teaching (3:8–11).

Titus 3:3

Being humble and treating everyone with respect is appropriate (3:2). This is especially true when we remember our own condition when God's kindness and love came to us (3:4; see Ephesians 2:1–4; 5:8; Colossians 3:7; 1 Peter 4:3).

Titus 3:4

- We should behave toward our fellow humans as God acted toward us—in kindness and love. God's salvation makes this possible.
- revealed (literally appeared): The Greek word relates to the coming of Christ (also in 2:11, 13; see study note on 1 Timothy 6:14).

Titus 3:4–7

This passage might be a summary or quote from traditional teaching (see 1 Timothy 1:15; 2:5–6).

Titus 3:5

- not by ... but by: The contrast is between human actions that might be thought to deserve salvation and God's grace (see Galatians 2:16). Salvation is through faith in God's mercy alone (Ephesians 2:8).
- washing of new birth: See Ezekiel 16:9; John 3:1–15; Ephesians 5:26; Hebrews 10:22; 2 Peter 1:9.
- and renewal by the Holy Spirit: This demonstrates a complete departure from the life of sin and death and a transfer into the life of purity (see also Romans 12:2; 2 Corinthians 5:17; Colossians 3:10).

Titus 3:7

- The first half of this verse summarizes 3:4–6. The second half supplies the purpose for what God did.
- made us right in his sight (literally having been justified): See Romans 3:20–28; Galatians 2:16–17.
- heirs with the hope of eternal life: The Spirit, as mentioned in Titus 3:5, is often connected to our status as heirs (see Romans 8:15–17; 1 Corinthians 6:9–11; Gal 4:6–7; Ephesians 1:13–14).

Titus 3:8

The trustworthy saying is 3:4–7 (compare 1 Timothy 1:15).

Titus 3:10–11

a divisive man: This refers to quarrelsome people who are difficult to correct or change (see 1:11, 13).

Titus 3:12

- Evidently Artemas or Tychicus would be Titus's replacement on Crete. Since Tychicus was in fact sent to Ephesus (see 2 Timothy 4:12), Artemas might have been the one who went to Crete.
- Nicopolis: Several cities had this name. This was most likely a major city on the western coast of the Greek peninsula (a piece of land surrounded mostly by water but connected to the mainland on one side). It is possible Paul had worked here before (see Romans 15:19, which mentions Paul's activity even further west).

Titus 3:12–15

The letter ends with news in 3:12, a final exhortation (or encouragement) in 3:13–14, greetings, and a blessing in 3:15.

Titus 3:13

- Zenas and Apollos were involved in spreading the good news about Jesus, and they might have been the ones who delivered this letter to Titus.
- Zenas was probably an expert in Roman law or a Roman jurist (the same word for lawyer is in Luke 7:30; 10:25). His Greek name (which means "gift of Zeus") makes it unlikely that he was an expert in Jewish law.
- Apollos is presumably the same man as in Acts 18:24; 19:1; 1 Corinthians 1:12; 3:4–6, 22; 4:6; 16:12.
- everything they need: See 1 Timothy 3:2; 3 John 1:5–8; compare Romans 15:24; 1 Corinthians 16:6, 11; 2 Corinthians 1:16.

Titus 3:14

- This final exhortation is connected to the responsibility to take care of Zenas and Apollos (see Romans 12:13; Ephesians 4:28; 1 Thessalonians 4:11; 1 Timothy 5:8, 16; 6:18).
- Our people (that is, followers of Christ) must involve themselves in the life-giving ministry of the good news rather than in the unproductive speculations of the false teachers.

Titus 3:15

all of you: The letter was addressed to Titus in 1:4, but the whole church was the audience for the letter.